

4.3.1 Language Investigation

Students may choose to pursue an area of individual interest. For example, this might include studies of:

- representations of different individuals, social groups or nationalities
- regional dialect
- gendered talk
- the language of new communication technologies
- children's language use
- norms and variations in usages of different kinds
- the language of the media
- code switching and mixing between English and other languages
- the language of different occupations or pastimes
- historical changes in English over time.

Students are not obliged to restrict themselves to those areas that are formally taught, as the basis of the investigation is the value of student-led enquiry supported by open learning. Therefore, any area seen by supervising teachers as yielding interesting questions about language in use may be chosen. Students can ask a number of fruitful questions, which can be generated by questions such as the following:

1. A genre-based investigation: what are the distinctive features of this type of language use?
2. A function/use-based investigation: what is the language used to do?
3. An attitudes-based investigation: how do people feel about this language?
4. A user-based investigation: who uses this type of language?

Students will need to decide what kind of data they collect:

- spoken language
- written language
- multimodal language
- word lists (ie lists of new words etc)

- attitudes to language
- uses of language
- views about language.

Underpinning this piece of research is the challenge that, in consultation with their supervising teacher, students should collect their own data as the basis of their study, as well as select their own approach for analysis.

Investigations need a specific focus, for example:

- the writing of two children aged 8
- features of the Devon dialect, based on a survey
- the language of wedding ceremonies from two different cultures
- the language of teachers' reports
- the language used in three different advertisements for a particular product
- how stories are told in a particular comic
- how travel guides represent a particular community
- the language of sports commentary
- how turntaking works in real-time writing online
- language patterns in the names of shops.

The list above is neither definitive nor prescriptive.

The investigation should contain the following sections:

Introduction

- brief discussion of the reasons for choosing the investigation focus
- what the investigation is trying to find out (aims).

Methodology

- an evaluative account of how the data was collected and organised for analysis
- approaches to analysis.

Analysis

- analysis and interpretation of the findings, responding to the aim of the investigation
- critical consideration of relevant concepts and issues surrounding the topic area
- analysis of the contextual influences upon the data collected.

Conclusion

- interpretation of the findings of the investigation linked to the aim/focus of the investigation.

References

- a list of all sources used (paper and web-based).

Appendices

- clean copies of the collected data
- evidence to support quantitative approaches.